



COVER HERO

Full-bleed hero — an iconic NSW scene (Sydney Harbour with the Opera House & Bridge at golden hour, or a dramatic coastal cliff). Landscape, ~4:3 upper crop



YOUR JOURNEY BEGINS HERE

New South Wales Relocation Guide

— WRITTEN BY ETHICARE RESOURCING · WARRANE / SYDNEY

A warm welcome, you're in good hands

Deciding to move your life and career to the other side of the world is a big step, and an exciting one. Whether New South Wales is already home to people you know or a brand-new chapter, I want you to feel supported from the very first conversation.

NSW is Australia's front door: the harbour city of Sydney, the largest economy and job market in the country, and, beyond it, surf coasts, wine country, world-heritage mountains and even snowfields. It asks a bit more of your budget than the other states, but it gives a great deal back, and its hospitals are among the finest in the southern hemisphere.

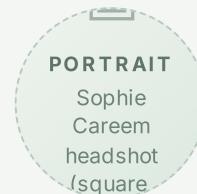
This guide walks you through healthcare, visas and registration, finances, housing, schooling and cost of living across the state, then breaks down the main places you might live so you can picture daily life in each. Think of it as the conversation we'd have over coffee, in your pocket, whenever you need it.

Welcome to New South Wales. We're so glad you're here, and we'll be alongside you every step of the way.

Warm regards,

Sophie

Sophie Careem · Founder & Director, Ethicare Resourcing



Sophie Careem

FOUNDER & DIRECTOR

*"A good move is measured in years,
not weeks, so we stay with you long
after you land."*

ETHICARE INSIGHT

NSW rewards a plan more than any other state. Sydney is superb but expensive, and the coast, the Hunter and the regional cities offer real value and strong demand. Where you settle shapes your budget, your commute and your lifestyle more than almost anything else.

WHAT'S INSIDE

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QUICK FACTS

Location	South-east, Australia
Capital	Sydney (~5.5M)
Population	~8.6M (largest state)
Climate	Temperate · four seasons
Main hospital	Royal Prince Alfred
Time zone	AEST / AEDT (UTC+10/11)

SOPHIE'S TIP

Read the Cost of Living and Cities sections early. In NSW, choosing the right area, and getting your rental application ready before you land, makes the single biggest difference to how smoothly you settle.

The harbour state

New South Wales is Australia's most populous state and its largest economy, home to Sydney and to two-thirds of the state's 8.6 million people, most living along a long, temperate coast.

8.6M

STATE RESIDENTS

~80%

OF ACTIVITY FROM SERVICES

2,100km

PACIFIC COASTLINE

**LANDSCAPE**

Wide landscape — a signature NSW scene (Sydney Harbour, the Blue Mountains' Three Sisters, or a surf beach). Landscape ~16:7

Sydney Harbour, the heart of Australia's largest city and economy.

Why many professionals choose NSW

- ✓ The largest healthcare job market in the country, led by Sydney's world-class tertiary hospitals.
- ✓ A true world city, harbour, beaches, dining and culture, with genuine four-season variety.
- ✓ From surf coasts to wine country, world-heritage mountains and winter snowfields, all in one state.
- ✓ Strong demand and better value in the Hunter, the Illawarra and the regional cities.

ETHICARE INSIGHT

Candidates often picture Australia as one job market. It isn't. NSW registers nationally through AHPRA but hires locally through its Local Health Districts, and demand in the Hunter, the Illawarra and rural NSW is strong, often with incentives a headline Sydney salary won't show.

OVERVIEW · CULTURE

Ancient country, world city

The Gadigal people of the Eora Nation are the traditional custodians of central Sydney, known as Warrane, part of one of the oldest living cultures on earth, a heritage increasingly woven into NSW life.

NSW is where modern Australia began, and it remains its most multicultural state, with communities from every corner of the world. Sydney is a genuine global city, its harbour, its beaches and its dining among the best anywhere, while Vivid Sydney lights up the winter and the Hunter Valley and Byron Bay draw people from across the country. Beyond the city, the pace softens quickly into coast, farmland and mountains.

SOPHIE'S TIP

Learn the local names early, Warrane (Sydney Cove) and the Country names across the state. Using them warmly is genuinely appreciated and helps you feel part of the community faster.



LANDSCAPE

Wide landscape — a cultural/city scene (Vivid Sydney lights, a harbour ferry, or a Blue Mountains lookout). Landscape ~16:7

From harbour to hinterland, NSW packs remarkable variety into one state.

Getting around

Sydney has one of Australia's best public-transport networks, and you rarely need a car in the inner city. Beyond the metro area, the state's scale means driving comes back into the picture, and so do tolls.

Opal card

Trains, metro, buses, ferries and light rail run on the tap-on Opal card, with fares capped at about \$50 a week (and roughly \$2.80 all day on Sundays). You can also tap on with a contactless bank card.

Driving & tolls

Australians drive on the left. Sydney has the densest toll network in the country, get an E-toll tag before you drive the motorways; weekly toll spend is now capped for eligible trips.

Trains & ferries

Sydney Trains and the driverless Metro reach far across the city, and the harbour ferries are a scenic commute in their own right.

Flying

Sydney Airport links to every capital and regional NSW; the new Western Sydney Airport is opening to add capacity.



LANDSCAPE

Wide landscape — a transport scene (a Sydney ferry passing the Opera House, or a Sydney Metro train).
Landscape ~16:7

A harbour ferry, one of the world's great commutes.

SOPHIE'S TIP

You can usually drive on a valid overseas licence for a period after arriving, but you'll need to transfer to a NSW licence once you're a resident. Sort an Opal card and an E-toll tag in your first week, the tag saves you the per-trip admin fees on Sydney's motorways.

A year in the NSW climate

NSW has a genuinely temperate, four-season climate, warm summers, crisp winters and, uniquely among the mainland states, real alpine snow. Remember, the seasons are flipped from the Northern Hemisphere.

Summer

DEC – FEB

25–27°

Autumn

MAR – MAY

18–23°

Winter

JUN – AUG

8–17°

Spring

SEP – NOV

18–24°

Figures are indicative for Sydney, which is warm and humid in summer and mild in winter. The north coast is subtropical; the tablelands and Blue Mountains are cooler with frosty winters; and the Snowy Mountains have a true alpine climate, with a ski season at Thredbo and Perisher from about June to September.

ETHICARE INSIGHT

Two things catch newcomers out. First, the UV is strong, sun protection is a year-round habit here, not a summer one. Second, NSW winters are genuinely cool and many homes have limited heating, so budget for warm bedding and a heater for your first winter, a point worth making to family before they arrive.



LANDSCAPE

Wide landscape — a seasonal scene (a summer surf beach, or snow at Thredbo). Landscape ~16:7

From summer surf to winter snow, NSW spans the seasons.

Healthcare in New South Wales

NSW runs Australia's largest public health system, universal Medicare cover, more than 220 public hospitals and a strong private sector, delivered through 15 Local Health Districts led by Sydney's tertiary centres.

Royal Prince Alfred (RPA)

One of the nation's premier tertiary referral hospitals, in Camperdown, renowned for trauma, transplants and research.

Westmead & Liverpool

Two of the country's largest hospitals, anchoring western and south-western Sydney with major trauma and specialist services.

Royal North Shore & St Vincent's

Leading teaching hospitals serving the north shore and inner east, with major emergency and specialist care.

Regional referral hospitals

John Hunter (Newcastle) leads the state outside Sydney; Wollongong, Coffs Harbour, Orange, Tamworth and Wagga Wagga anchor their regions.

GOOD TO KNOW

Eligibility for Medicare usually begins once you hold an appropriate visa. Reciprocal Health Care Agreements give some countries limited Medicare access. Ambulance cover is not automatic in NSW, unlike Queensland there's a fee unless you hold ambulance cover or a concession, so many people add it to their private health insurance.

Working as a practitioner here

Written for clinicians, not tourists: the things that actually shape your working life and take-home pay.

What to ask about

Salary packaging	Big tax saving
Shift & roster patterns	Penalties vary
Public vs private	Different pay & pace
Parking & commute	Real cost in Sydney
CPD allowance	Time & funding differ
Professional indemnity	Check employer cover

Professional associations

Joining your college or association early helps with CPD, networking and staying current with local practice standards.

Career progression

NSW's mix of major tertiary, coastal and rural roles means broad experience, and regional posts can accelerate progression.

ETHICARE INSIGHT

Public-health and not-for-profit roles let you "package" part of your salary before tax. In a high-cost city like Sydney this matters even more, it can lift take-home pay meaningfully, yet many international staff don't set it up in their first months. Ask on day one.



LANDSCAPE

Wide landscape — a healthcare scene (a modern Sydney hospital, or clinicians in a bright ward).
Landscape ~16:7

Visas & the right to work

Most healthcare professionals arrive on a skilled or employer-sponsored visa. Your Ethicare contact will guide you to the right pathway for your role and circumstances.

PATHWAY	IN SHORT	TYPICALLY SUITS
Employer-sponsored (482)	An employer nominates you for a skilled role	Those with a job offer
Skilled Nominated (190)	State-nominated permanent skilled migration	In-demand occupations
Skilled Work Regional (491)	Points-tested pathway tied to regional NSW	Those open to the regions
Partner / family	Based on a relationship with a resident or citizen	Family-linked moves

GOOD TO KNOW

Visa rules change regularly. Always confirm current requirements with the Department of Home Affairs (homeaffairs.gov.au) and your Ethicare contact before making decisions. The NSW skilled-nomination programs (190 and 491) are run by the state and update their criteria through the year.

Professional registration

Most healthcare professions are regulated nationally through AHPRA, the Australian Health Practitioner Regulation Agency, and its profession-specific boards.

One national register

Work anywhere in Australia

Once registered with AHPRA you can work anywhere in the country, including all of NSW, registration is national, not state-by-state.

Qualification assessment

Overseas qualifications are assessed against Australian standards; some roles require bridging programs or exams.

English language

You'll usually need to evidence English proficiency through an approved test or a recognised pathway.

Start early

Registration takes time, begin gathering documents and references well before you plan to travel.

ETHICARE INSIGHT

The single biggest cause of delayed start dates we see is documents gathered too late. Certified copies of qualifications, references and ID take longer to assemble than people expect, begin the moment you're seriously considering the move.



LANDSCAPE

Wide landscape — a calm, aspirational scene (a quiet harbour morning, or a study/desk detail).

Landscape ~16:7

Starting your paperwork early is the surest way to arrive calm.

Setting up your finances

Getting your finances in order early makes day-to-day life much easier. Most of this can be started before you arrive.

Opening a bank account

The major banks are CommBank, Westpac, NAB and ANZ. Westpac began life in Sydney in 1817 as the Bank of New South Wales, Australia's first bank. Many let you open online before you arrive, then verify ID in branch with your passport.

Tax File Number (TFN)

Every worker needs a TFN from the ATO. Apply online once you arrive and give the number to payroll so you're taxed correctly. Without it, you'll be taxed at the highest rate.

SOPHIE'S TIP

Open your bank account before you fly where you can, having an account ready makes your payroll setup and first rent payment far smoother in those hectic first weeks.

The money set-up, in order

- 1 Activate your bank account, verify ID in branch, order a debit card and online banking.
- 2 Apply for your TFN, online via the ATO, then give it to payroll immediately.
- 3 Choose your super fund, or accept the employer default, then review later.

- 4 Set up salary packaging, ask payroll or your provider on day one if you're in public health.
- 5 Register for Medicare, if eligible under your visa or a reciprocal agreement.
- 6 Get a local SIM & number, many banking and government steps need an Australian mobile.

SOPHIE'S TIP

The salary is only half the picture, and in Sydney the bridge between arriving and your first full pay is the part to plan for most carefully. Budget for temporary accommodation, a rental bond (typically four weeks' rent) plus up to two weeks' rent in advance, a first car if you need one, and setting up a home. None of it is dramatic, but in a high-cost city it adds up, and planning for it removes almost all of the early stress.

Sophie Careem · Founder & Director



LANDSCAPE

Wide landscape — a warm 'settling in' scene (a kitchen/coffee moment, or a leafy Sydney street).
Landscape ~16:7

Planning for the first few weeks removes almost all of the early stress.

What life costs in NSW

Let's be honest: Sydney is Australia's most expensive city, and housing is the main reason. The good news is that the coast, the Hunter and the regional cities cost far less, and a plan makes Sydney very liveable.

\$780

3-BED HOUSE, SYDNEY / WK
(APPROX MEDIAN)

\$1.87

APPROX. PETROL PRICE /
LITRE

\$50

WEEKLY OPAL FARE CAP

Everyday item · approx. price (A\$)

1 litre of milk	\$1.60 – \$3.00
Loaf of bread	\$3.00 – \$5.00
Dozen eggs	\$5 – \$9
Flat white coffee	\$4.50 – \$6.50
Mid-range meal for one	\$28 – \$45
Home broadband	\$70 – \$100 / mo

Example monthly budget · one person (A\$)

Rent (room / small 1-bed)	\$1,700 – \$3,000
Power & water	\$160 – \$280
Internet	\$70 – \$100
Transport (Opal cap)	~\$200
Groceries	\$480 – \$720
Entertainment	\$200 – \$420
Estimated total	\$2,810 – \$4,720

10 things nobody tells you before moving to NSW

1 Get an E-toll tag first. Sydney has the country's densest toll network; without a tag you'll pay admin fees on every trip.

2 The rental market is a contest. Expect to apply on the spot with references ready, and four weeks' bond plus up to two weeks' rent in advance.

3 Cap your travel with Opal. Weekly spend is capped near \$50, and Sundays are about \$2.80 all day, even out to the Blue Mountains or Newcastle.

4 Winters are genuinely cool. Many homes have little heating, budget for a heater and warm bedding for your first winter.

5 Ambulance isn't automatically free. Unlike Queensland, add ambulance cover to your health insurance.

6 Apartments come with strata. If you rent a unit, know that building rules and levies shape life; ask before you sign.

7 Sydney is vast. 'Nearby' suburbs can be an hour apart in traffic, let your work site lead your search.

8 The UV is relentless. Sunscreen is a daily, year-round habit here, not a summer one.

9 Beaches are free, parking isn't. Coastal parking fills early and is often paid, public transport is easier on summer weekends.

10 There's real snow. The Snowy Mountains have a winter ski season, a genuine surprise for many newcomers.

Where you might live

NSW is more than Sydney. Here's an orientation to the six main places our healthcare professionals move to, from the harbour city to the coast, the Hunter and the Riverina, each with its own pace, cost and lifestyle.



CITY

Sydney Opera House /
harbour / a beach
suburb (portrait ~3:4)

SYDNEY · THE CAPITAL

A world city on the water

5.5M

\$780

30min

Metro pop.

Median house / wk

CBD to beaches

Home to NSW's largest tertiary hospitals and the widest healthcare job market in Australia. Harbour, beaches, dining and culture at world-city level, at world-city prices, with everything from inner-city apartments to leafy family suburbs.



CITY

Newcastle beach /
harbour / Nobbys
Lighthouse (portrait
~3:4)

NEWCASTLE · AWABAKAL & WORIMI COUNTRY

Harbour city, coastal value

~500K

~2hr

John Hunter

Metro pop.

North of Sydney

Trauma centre

The state's second city, with beaches, a working harbour and a lively food scene. John Hunter Hospital is the busiest trauma centre outside Sydney, and housing is far more affordable than the capital. A favourite for lifestyle and value.



CITY

Wollongong / Sea Cliff
Bridge / escarpment
coast (portrait ~3:4)

WOLLONGONG · DHARAWAL COUNTRY

Coast, escarpment & university city

~300K

~1.5hr

5min

Local pop.

South of Sydney

To the beach

Where the escarpment meets the sea, an hour and a half south of Sydney. Wollongong Hospital anchors the Illawarra, the university brings energy, and the beaches and Sea Cliff Bridge are on the doorstep. Strong value and a relaxed pace.



CITY

Central Coast beach /
Terrigal / a lake at dusk
(portrait ~3:4)

CENTRAL COAST · DARKINJUNG COUNTRY

Beaches, lakes & commuter belt

~350K

~1hr

Gosford

Local pop.

To Sydney by rail

Regional hospital

A string of beaches and waterways between Sydney and Newcastle, with Gosford Hospital as the regional centre. Popular with families for its lifestyle and rail links, you can live by the water and still reach the city.



CITY

Coffs Harbour jetty /
beaches / Muttonbird
Island (portrait ~3:4)

COFFS HARBOUR · GUMBAYNGGIRR COUNTRY

Mid North Coast beaches

~75K

~5hr

Referral

Local pop.

North of Sydney

Base hospital

A subtropical beach city halfway to Brisbane, with a redeveloped base hospital serving the Mid North Coast. Bananas, whales and endless beaches, relaxed, affordable and in real demand for health staff.



CITY

Wagga Wagga /
Murrumbidgee River /
rural plains (portrait
~3:4)

WAGGA WAGGA · WIRADJURI COUNTRY

The Riverina's regional hub

~68K

~1.5hr

Base

Local pop.

Flight to Sydney

Referral hospital

The largest inland city in NSW, on the Murrumbidgee in the Riverina. A confident regional centre built on agriculture, defence and education, with Wagga Wagga Base Hospital and healthcare demand that often comes with real incentives.

City, coast or region?

For healthcare staff, the choice isn't only lifestyle, the coast and the regions often carry the strongest value and, in rural NSW, real incentives.

IF YOU WANT ...	CONSIDER	BECAUSE
The widest job market	Sydney	Tertiary hospitals, most vacancies
Coastal city & value	Newcastle	Trauma centre, affordable, beaches
Coast, escarpment & uni life	Wollongong	Illawarra hub, easy Sydney access
Family lifestyle by the water	Central Coast	Beaches & lakes, rail to Sydney
Subtropical beach living	Coffs Harbour	Mid North Coast referral centre
Regional life & incentives	Wagga Wagga	Riverina hub, rural incentives

ETHICARE INSIGHT

Rural and regional roles across NSW, especially in the Riverina, the west and the far north, frequently come with relocation assistance, accommodation support and retention incentives that a headline Sydney salary won't show, and your money stretches much further. If you're open to the regions, tell us early, it can change the maths considerably.



LANDSCAPE

Wide landscape — an evocative regional NSW scene (a Riverina river bend, a vineyard in the Hunter, or a country road at dusk). Landscape ~16:7

Beyond Sydney, NSW offers space, value and strong demand for health staff.

Finding a place to live

From Sydney apartments to coastal homes and regional towns, where you live in NSW shapes your commute and your budget more than anywhere. In a tight market, preparation wins.



LANDSCAPE

Wide landscape — a NSW home exterior (a Federation terrace, a coastal house, or a leafy suburban street). Landscape ~16:7

From harbourside terraces to coastal homes, NSW housing spans every style.

Rentals move quickly, especially in Sydney, where you should be ready to apply on the spot. You'll usually apply with ID, references and proof of income, then pay a bond (typically four weeks' rent) lodged through Rental Bonds Online, plus up to two weeks' rent in advance. Many newcomers rent short-term first to learn an area. The main sites are **realestate.com.au** (largest) and **domain.com.au**.

Choosing your area, the order that saves the most stress

- 1 Fix your work site first.** In a city as large as Sydney, your commute decides everything, settle it before you fall for a suburb.
- 2 Check school catchments** if you have children. Local intake is guaranteed; out-of-area isn't.

3 Shortlist two or three areas and rent short-term in one before committing.

4 If it's an apartment, read the strata. Building rules and levies shape daily life, ask before you sign.

Utilities & getting set up

Power & gas

Choose a retailer (AGL, Origin, EnergyAustralia and others); the networks are Ausgrid, Endeavour and Essential. Set up on move-in.

Water

Sydney Water or your regional provider; if renting, most water charges are the landlord's.

Internet

NBN via Telstra, Optus, TPG or Aussie Broadband.

Setting up home

Kmart, IKEA and Bunnings furnish a first home fast; Marketplace for second-hand.

SOPHIE'S TIP

No Australian rental references? Bring landlord references from home, proof of income and savings, and your job offer, all as clean PDFs ready to send. In Sydney's market, a complete, instant application often beats a longer local history.

Groceries, food & community

The essentials in one place, the big chains, the budget picks, and where NSW's many communities find the flavours of home, this is one of the most multicultural states on earth.

The big chains

Woolworths & Coles for full-range everywhere; ALDI for the cheapest weekly shop; IGA and independents for neighbourhood top-ups, vital in regional towns.

Flavours of home

Cabramatta and Bankstown for Vietnamese and South-East Asian; Lakemba and Auburn for Lebanese, Turkish and Halal; Harris Park for Little India; Eastwood and Hurstville for Chinese and Korean.



LANDSCAPE

Wide landscape — a food/market scene (Sydney Fish Market, a multicultural street eatery, or a farmers' market). Landscape ~16:7

The Sydney Fish Market and the city's food precincts are world-class.

SOPHIE'S TIP

Bring your own bags, lightweight single-use plastic bags are banned across NSW, and most people keep a few reusable ones in the car for exactly this reason.

GOOD TO KNOW

Sydney has Australia's widest range of specialist food. Halal butchers and grocers are easy to find (Lakemba, Auburn, Bankstown); kosher supplies cluster in the eastern suburbs (Bondi, Rose Bay) around the country's largest Jewish community; and South African, British and every Asian and Middle-Eastern staple is well stocked. In the regional centres it's more limited, Newcastle, Wollongong and the larger towns have good halal ranges, but dedicated kosher supplies are largely Sydney-based, so many regional families stock up on a city trip or order online.

— FAITH & COMMUNITY · PLACES OF WORSHIP

Religion & places of worship

Australia has no state religion and law protects freedom of belief. NSW is the country's most religiously diverse state: at the last census around a third of residents reported no religion, Christianity remained the largest faith, and Islam, Hinduism, Buddhism, Sikhism and Judaism are all large and well established, most strongly across Greater Sydney, with active communities in the regional centres too.

Most communities list service and prayer times online and warmly welcome newcomers, often one of the quickest ways to build a support network after you arrive.



COMMUNITY

Portrait image — a NSW place of worship
or community scene (~3:4)

The main faiths & where to find them

Christianity

Catholic, Anglican, Uniting, Pentecostal and Orthodox churches statewide. Landmark cathedrals include St Mary's (Catholic) and St Andrew's (Anglican) in Sydney.

Islam

One of Australia's largest Muslim communities, with major mosques including Lakemba, plus mosques and musallas across the suburbs and in Newcastle, Wollongong and beyond. See the Muslims NSW / ANIC directories.

Hinduism

The Sri Venkateswara Temple at Helensburgh and temples across western Sydney serve a large community, with festivals through the year.

Buddhism

Many temples and centres, including the Nan Tien Temple near Wollongong, the largest Buddhist temple in the southern hemisphere.

Sikhism

Gurdwaras across Sydney, including in the west and south-west, welcome worshippers and visitors, with community kitchens (langar) open to all.

Judaism

Australia's largest Jewish community, centred on Sydney's eastern suburbs, with synagogues, schools and kosher supplies, plus the Sydney Jewish Museum.

SOPHIE'S TIP

If regular worship matters to you, factor it into where you settle. In Sydney it's rarely an issue, but in the regions your nearest mosque, temple or gurdwara may be further away, worth confirming alongside schools and your commute.

Harbour, coast, mountains & snow

Few places pack in this much variety, world-city harbour, endless surf coast, world-heritage mountains, wine country and, in winter, real snow, much of it within a couple of hours of Sydney.



LANDSCAPE

Wide landscape — a hero recreation scene (Sydney Harbour aerial, the Three Sisters, or a Jervis Bay beach). Landscape ~16:7

World-heritage mountains and endless coast, both within reach of the city.

Ten things not to miss

- 1 **Sydney Harbour**, the Opera House, the Bridge climb and a ferry to Manly.
- 2 **Bondi to Bronte**, Australia's most famous coastal walk, then a swim.
- 3 **Blue Mountains**, the Three Sisters, waterfalls and eucalypt valleys, a world-heritage escape.
- 4 **Hunter Valley**, Australia's oldest wine region, an easy weekend from Sydney.
- 5 **Byron Bay**, the laid-back capital of the Northern Rivers, and the mainland's most easterly point.
- 6 **Jervis Bay**, Hyams Beach and some of the whitest sand on earth.
- 7 **Snowy Mountains**, ski Thredbo and Perisher in winter, hike Kosciuszko in summer.
- 8 **Port Stephens**, dolphins, giant dunes and calm bays north of Newcastle.
- 9 **Royal National Park**, the world's second-oldest national park, coast and bush south of the city.
- 10 **Broken Hill & the outback**, big-sky red-earth country and living mining history out west.

SOPHIE'S TIP

Pace yourself, you don't need to see it all in the first month. The best discoveries come from locals at work, so ask your new colleagues where they escape to on weekends, whether that's the coast in summer or the snow in winter.



LANDSCAPE

Wide landscape — a second recreation scene (a Hunter Valley vineyard, a coastal walk, or the snowfields). Landscape ~16:7

From vineyards to snowfields, the best of NSW is closer than you think.

Schooling & family life

NSW offers a full range of early childhood education, schools and universities, run by the state's Department of Education. The school year runs late January to mid-December across four terms, a flip from the Northern Hemisphere calendar worth planning around.

Early childhood

Long daycare, preschool and family day care for ages 0–5, with subsidies. Preschool is the year before Kindergarten.

Primary

Kindergarten (first year) through Year 6, across public, Catholic and independent schools.

Secondary

Years 7–12, ending with the Higher School Certificate (HSC), leading to university or training.

Tertiary

The Universities of Sydney, UNSW, UTS, Macquarie, Newcastle and Wollongong, plus TAFE NSW across the state.

Public school fees for visa-holder families

Handled by the NSW Department of Education's Temporary Residents Program, and, as in most states, many healthcare families are exempt.

SITUATION	WHAT APPLIES
482 holder in an occupation on the MLTSSL / relevant skills list	Exempt from tuition (a small application fee applies)
482 family in an eligible regional NSW postcode	May qualify for a separate regional exemption
Where tuition does apply (flat annual, by year level)	~\$5,600 primary to ~\$6,800 senior (indicative)
New Zealand citizens	Enrol as locals, no tuition fee

ETHICARE INSIGHT

NSW's school-fee rules are more favourable for clinicians than they first appear. Dependents of 482 visa holders whose occupation sits on the Medium and Long-term Strategic Skills List, which covers many nursing, medical and allied-health roles, are exempt from state-school tuition, paying only a modest application fee. There's also a separate exemption for 482 families living in eligible regional postcodes, and income-based waivers where fees do apply. Confirm your occupation on your visa grant, and note that education costs can sometimes be salary-packaged.



FAMILY

Portrait image — a child walking to school / family scene (~3:4)

School catchments come first

For NSW public schools, your home address determines your local-intake (catchment) school, children inside the zone are guaranteed a place, while out-of-area places depend on capacity, and popular schools can be heavily oversubscribed. Boundaries can run street-by-street, so always check the exact address before you sign.

For families, the school decision usually leads the housing decision here, deciding it first prevents an expensive mid-year move.

Employment for your partner

A move only works if it works for the whole family. The good news: on most skilled and employer-sponsored visas your partner is included with full work rights, free to take any job, full or part-time, with any employer.

Work rights come as standard

Partners added to a 482, 186, or skilled 189/190/491 visa generally have unrestricted work rights, no separate employer sponsorship needed. Always confirm the exact conditions on your grant letter.

The country's biggest job market

NSW is Australia's largest economy, with demand across healthcare, education, finance, construction, technology, hospitality and professional services, strongest in Greater Sydney, with real opportunities in the regions too.

Helping your partner land work

- 1 Reformat the CV to Australian style, concise, achievement-led, no photo or date of birth. Set up a strong LinkedIn with a NSW location.
- 2 Search the main boards, SEEK, Indeed and Jora, plus NSW Health's careers site and I Work for NSW for public-sector roles.
- 3 Check if the profession is regulated, teaching, nursing, trades and others need registration or a skills assessment. Start it before you arrive.

ETHICARE INSIGHT

Partner employment is one of the biggest factors in a move succeeding, so we treat it as part of the plan, not an afterthought. Tell us early what your partner does; if they're also in healthcare, we can often help them directly.

Your relocation timeline

A simple countdown from decision to arrival, so nothing important gets left to the last minute.

12 months before	Start AHPRA registration; gather qualifications, references and ID.
6 months before	Confirm your visa pathway; open an Australian bank account online.
3 months before	Book temporary accommodation; plan schools and catchments.
1 month before	Arrange money transfers; sort flights, shipping and insurance.
Arrival week	Activate bank account, apply for TFN, get a local SIM, Opal card and E-toll tag.
First month	Set up super & salary packaging, find a GP, settle the family.

Key numbers & contacts

EMERGENCY & HEALTH

Emergency **000** · healthdirect **1800 022 222**
Lifeline **13 11 14** · Police (non-urgent) **131 444**

EVERYDAY SERVICES

Tax (ATO) **ato.gov.au**
Immigration **homeaffairs.gov.au**
Service NSW **service.nsw.gov.au**

SOPHIE'S TIP

The candidates who arrive calm are the ones who started the registration paperwork a year out. Everything else can move quickly, that one step can't.

We guide you through every stage

Relocating overseas can feel overwhelming. From the first conversation to long after you arrive, we're here to support you, the same six-step journey you'll find on our website.

STAGE 1 OF SIX

Discovery call

Understanding your goals, your family situation and whether Australia or New Zealand may be the right fit.

STAGE 2 OF SIX

Eligibility & registration

Assessing registration requirements and helping you understand your options clearly.

STAGE 3 OF SIX

Opportunities & interviews

Discussing locations, employers and salaries, then preparing you for interviews and what employers look for.

STAGE 4 OF SIX

Offer & decision support

Helping you evaluate opportunities and make the decision that's right for you.

STAGE 5 OF SIX

Visa & relocation guidance

Supporting you through the practicalities of moving overseas.

STAGE 6 OF SIX

Settling in

Ongoing support as you begin your new life and career, long after you arrive.

THE ETHICARE PROMISE

Ready to explore opportunities?

Most agencies step back once you start. We don't. From your first enquiry to settling your family and growing your career, your Ethicare contact stays with you, because a good move is measured in years, not weeks. Pair this guide with your profession guide and current opportunities in New South Wales.

[Talk to the Team](#)[View Current Opportunities](#)

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